

Resistance is futile

A recent New Yorker article titled “The pointlessness of unplugging” was the source of much debate and heated discussion this month at Digit. The article was centered around an annual event which urges participants to abstain from the use of technology for a whole day. In essence, you are to wrench yourself away from phones, tablets, computers and televisions – basically anything that’s connected – and throw yourself into a self-imposed digital exile of sorts. Sounds horrifying? To someone like me it doesn’t sound horrifying per se, but absurd, and pointless for sure. Before I get into the “why”, let’s first understand more about this emerging sub-culture.

As it turns out, people have been going on these detox adventures for quite some time. I remember marvelling at Paul Miller’s “year without the internet” experiment which he notably did as a staff writer at The Verge (still haven’t figured out how that worked). The few videos I saw before the experiment started getting boring, had an underlying sentiment that wasn’t very positive. The experiment had its highlights sure – he finally undertook the road trip he always wanted to take to see his little nephews and nieces – but overall, I felt Paul started getting increasingly despondent. Only subtle hints alluded to this of course, but I wouldn’t be surprised if at the end of the year he went on to proclaim that the experience was “enriching” or “fulfilling” or some other such adjective. But I wouldn’t buy into it.

I’ve observed that digital abstinence drives are mostly undertaken with unclear objectives. Some see the time spent in the digital world as a waste and therefore desperately want to “reclaim” control over the time-sapping void that is the internet. Sure, if all you do online is watch Justin Bieber videos and giggle at 9GAG posts then yes, you not only need to detox but also sign up for rehab. But if you’re spending your time productively interacting with people and enriching your knowledge, I don’t see why the digital life you lead should be considered inferior to the time you spend doing those same things IRL (in real life). Also, unpluggers don’t unplug for so called benefits of unplugging but rather

the kick they’d get from a triumphant return. Such messages, ironically, aren’t uncommon on our timelines: “Just spent a week away from Facebook. Wow so refreshing. Did you miss me?”

Robert is all for taking breaks from technology, and in fact argues that digital dependence can be crippling. If you asked me how many phone numbers I remember off the top of my head, I’d be embarrassed to tell you the answer. On a daily basis, facts, figures and important information also admittedly slip through the cracks these days. Instead what’s remained is a selective memory and neural pathways that itch to find a search bar. But can “breaks” from technology really improve our mental prowess? The only purpose such detox trips would serve is give you a greater appreciation of technology for whence you return to it. Much like what Vipassana does or is supposed to do for the soul.

Don’t get me wrong. I’m all for spending time with family, having a nice sit-down dinner with conversations rather than a zombie supper in front of the idiot box’s glow. Or being in the moment and enjoying a rock concert rather than tweeting about that “killer guitar solo” I just saw. But there’d be no greater folly than to take this technology abstinence a step further and cloister yourself from it entirely. There’s no pride nor should there be any in being a self-proclaimed luddite. Like the New Yorker article said, “We are only ever tourists in the land of no technology, our visas valid for a day or a week or a year”. Nothing more. 



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“Can breaks from technology really improve our mental prowess?”

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth Parwatay'.

Got feedback about this column?
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